

The Glorious Cakrasaṃvara, King of Tantras, the Secret and Inconceivable

Śrī Cakrasaṃvara Guhyācintya Tantrarāja · Toh 385 · Derge Kangyur

དཔལ་ལའམ་ལོ་ལོ་ལོ་པ་གསང་བ་བསམ་གསུམ་མ་ཁྱེ་མ་ཁྱེ་པ་འཛིན་ཀྱི་འཛིན་པ།

Toh 385 in the Kangyur is known in English as The Glorious Cakrasaṃvara, King of Tantras, the Secret and Inconceivable, in Sanskrit as the Śrī Cakrasaṃvara Guhyācintya Tantrarāja, and in Tibetan as Dpal 'khor lo sdom pa gsang ba bsaṃ gyis mi khyab pa'i rgyud kyi rgyal po. It is a tantra of the Highest Yoga class belonging to the Mother Tantra tradition, centered on the deity Cakrasaṃvara, also known as Heruka, and concerned with the secret and inconceivable nature of saṃsāric phenomena, the union of great bliss and emptiness, and the esoteric teachings imparted by the Blessed One to Vajrapāṇi and an assembled retinue. The text opens in the classic sūtra-style frame of "thus did I hear," situating the Buddha in meditative union with a vajra-queen as the embodiment of the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas, before moving into verse dialogue on the ultimate nature of conventional appearances. As Toh 385 in the Kangyur, it belongs to the tantric section of that great Tibetan canonical collection and stands as one of the important scriptural sources for the Cakrasaṃvara cycle, which occupies a central place in the Vajrayāna traditions of Tibet.

In the language of India: Śrī Cakrasaṃvara Guhyācintyatantrarāja. In the language of Tibet: The Glorious Cakrasaṃvara, King of Tantras, the Secret and Inconceivable.

Homage to the Glorious Great Bliss.

Thus did I hear at one time. The Blessed One, the Tathāgata, dwelt in meditative equipoise within the bhaga of the vajra-queen, the embodiment of the body, speech, and mind of all Tathāgatas. At that time, all those gathered in the retinue became weary of the phenomena of conventional saṃsāra.

Then Vajrapāṇi, the Lord of Secrets, made this request:

Ho! Ho! Blessed Heruka,
what is the very nature
of the phenomena of conventional saṃsāra?
I beseech the Chief to explain this to me.

The Blessed One declared:

Appearing as deceptive extremes and signs,
those are precisely the phenomena of conventional saṃsāra.
The nature of mind is inconceivable —
that is the intrinsic nature of the phenomena of saṃsāra.

Vajrapāṇi asked further:

The inconceivable nature of mind —
its divisions and discordant numbers,
its modes of time and abiding,
the times and methods of entering,
the measure of abiding and its gradations —
I beseech the Chief to explain these to me.

The Blessed One declared:

Habitual tendencies, afflictions, and the body of gnosis,
the six classes entwined like trunk and branch —
their nature is beyond the path of speech.
That suchness is inconceivable
and is the very essence of the buddhas of the three times,
the secret of the mind of all the Sugatas.
This I now shall explain — so listen.

Free from the extremes of permanence and annihilation,
arising and cessation and the rest,
mind-nature is self-aware,
primordially free of conceptual elaboration, bliss itself.
That meaning is definitively inconceivable.

That suchness, divided into superior, middling, and inferior,
is to be known in three aspects.

First: self-awareness is inconceivable.

Cause, path, and signs are inconceivable.

Extremes and afflictions are inconceivable.

Phenomena and view and conduct are inconceivable.

Syllables are inconceivable.

In brief, that suchness is set forth by way of distinctions.

Form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and mental phenomena —
those phenomena of suchness are inconceivable.

The syllable A is the supreme syllable:

arising from within, it is unborn,
yet it becomes the cause of all birth.
The supreme syllable is inconceivable.

Ablutions from meat residue, bathing, cleanliness,
ornaments, nakedness, ash-smeared clothing and the rest;
alcohol, ambrosia, meat as well,
mother, sister, daughter and others —
conduct as play is inconceivable.

For the sentient beings I am to tame,
the scope of their aspirations is without limit.
Therefore, through the vehicle that is without limit,
the view of that suchness is inconceivable.

The words of permanence and annihilation, superimposition and denigration,
dependence on extremes —
the abiding of suchness in extremes is inconceivable.

Attachment, aversion, delusion and the rest —
the afflictions are inconceivable.

Trembling, leaping, warmth and the rest —
the signs themselves are inconceivable.

Visualizing deities, prāṇa, channels and the rest —
the path itself is inconceivable.

Self-awareness like clouds and rain in the sky,
the six perfections and the rest —
the cause itself is inconceivable.

Free from all conventional designations of cause and result,
unstained by the dust of striving,
uncontrived like a sky without clouds —
the characteristics both common and particular:
self-awareness is inconceivable.

The syllable A, together with the stroke marker, the serpentine curve and the
rest,
through twelve and further divisions —
the extensive divisions of syllables.

Form — pleasant, unpleasant and so on,
extending through nineteen kinds down to subtle atoms;
sounds and the rest likewise,
eight sounds, three smells, six tastes,
eleven kinds of touch, mental phenomena likewise —
some compounded, some uncompounded:
the extensive divisions of phenomena.

The three vehicles, one hundred and eight,
and however many perceptions there are —
the extensive divisions of views.

The path of accumulation, the path of preparation,
the path of seeing, the path of cultivation, the path of completion —
the extensive divisions of the path.

The signs of mind: the permanent, the signs of māra, the signs of elements —
the extensive divisions of signs.

From tīrthikas, pratyekabuddhas, and śrāvakas
all the way through to the conduct of the Vajra-holder —
the extensive divisions of conduct.

From eternalism, nihilism, superimposition, and denigration,
through the extremes of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa,
and on to the extremes of skillful means and wisdom —
the extensive divisions of extremes.

Attachment and the rest: twenty-one thousand,
together with the root and proximate afflictions —
and likewise with aversion and the rest:
the extensive divisions of afflictions.

Thorough defilement and complete purification,
great attachment, generosity, and so forth —
the extensive divisions of causes.

Mind, space, gnosis,
buddha, luminosity, union, and the rest —
the extensive divisions of self-awareness.

Appearing as characteristics imputed by intellect,
superimposition and denigration,

non-sequential aspiration seeking distinction,
accepting even the most subtle, positing through intellect —
and even establishing buddhahood itself:
however it may be contrived, that is an extreme,
and whatever view falls into extremes
is not self-awareness, not other-awareness, not mind.
It is neither conventional truth nor ultimate truth.

Self-awareness as dry logic,
and claiming the Middle Way while falling into extremes —
these are contrary to mind-itself, self-awareness,
the inexpressible and inconceivable.
Free from these, there is the great primordial wisdom of self-awareness,
which is inconceivable.

With the white virtuous qualities such as generosity and the rest,
and through the universal aspect of self-awareness,
in relation to the great primordial wisdom of self-awareness,
there is not so much as a hair's breadth of conventional designation —
not skillful means, not what arises from skillful means,
not cause, not effect, nor anything of the sort —
because it is self-arisen primordial wisdom.

Therefore, even the faults of attachment and the rest
do not obscure it:
they are like clouds in the sky.

By the distinction of self-awareness and other-awareness,
sentient beings and buddhas are divided into two.
Self-awareness is like a cloudless sky;
other-awareness is like conceptuality in the sky.

When clouds and the rest are scattered by the wind
and cloudless sky-like luminosity appears,
and other-awareness is freed from conceptual thought —
that, free from obscuration, is called buddha,
and it amounts to self-awareness alone.

For example: a person looking at the sky —
clouds have obscured the person's eyes,
yet the sky itself is unobscured, just as it is.

Numerically, the first is one:
from other-awareness having become self-awareness,
purification is not liberation by another.
Here, self-awareness alone —
that very reality is to be recognized and ascertained.

Thorough defilement and complete purification,
apprehended and apprehender, skillful means and wisdom —
the inconceivable: the second.

From the intrinsic nature of body, speech, and mind:
the liberations of emptiness, signlessness,
and wishlessness, and the body, speech, and mind of a buddha —
the inconceivable: the third.

Loving-kindness, compassion, joy, and equanimity:
from the intrinsic nature of earth, water, fire, and wind,
their number is fixed at four —
joy and the rest likewise.
The inconceivable: the fourth.

The five buddha families, the five buddhas,
the five aggregates, and the five of attachment and aversion —
the inconceivable: the fifth.

From the intrinsic nature of the six perfections:
the six objects, the six sense faculties, and so forth —
the inconceivable: the sixth.

And hundreds and so forth: the numbers are inconceivable.

Those who hold that self-awareness and other-awareness
have dwelt together since beginningless time,
abiding in the manner of a body and its shadow —
and who maintain that, at the time of ordinary beings,
other-awareness exists without self-awareness —
this too is great confusion and impropriety.

Those who abandon other-awareness while seeking self-awareness,
who abandon saṃsāra to attain nirvāṇa:
some conceive of saṃsāra and nirvāṇa
as two things to be abandoned and adopted by awareness.
Such and similar are the demons (māras) of views.

For those who hold to awareness: one hundred and ten.
The Great Vehicle: three thousand sūtras.
Śrāvakas and pratyekabuddhas: two hundred.
Viṣṇu (Viṣṇu, the Pervader), the Fierce One (Rudra), and the rest:
the demons of views are inconceivable.

Self-awareness is primordially unborn,
empty, unmodified, spontaneously present,
filled to the brim with the flavor of great bliss —

If one knows all of saṃsāra throughout the three realms,
then buddhahood itself is within saṃsāra,
and saṃsāra itself is nirvāṇa —
free from the demons of views.

There is no self-awareness and no other-awareness.
Both ultimate and conventional truth are abandoned.
There is no mind, no sky, no nature of reality.
There is no delusion and no non-delusion.
There is no vehicle and no gradual progression.
Neither inferior nor superior exists.
There is no gnosis and no bliss.
Free from extremes, it does not abide in the Middle Way.
It abides in the inconceivable.

One who realizes and inwardly comprehends this,
who has no fear and contrives neither superimposition nor denial,
is the eldest child of the Victors,
the supreme among all children of the Victors.
Blessed by the Vajra-Holder (Vajrapāṇi),
they are the object of veneration of all the ḍākinīs.
Entering the ground of a vidyādhara,
one must diligently train in meditative equipoise
and come to abide on the ground of a vidyādhara.

Having abided on the ground of a vidyādhara,
one enters the ground of the Vajra-Holder.
Abiding on the ground of the Vajra-Holder —
the fifteenth ground, which is the nature of all grounds —
one accomplishes the two bodies for the benefit of others.
By the power of the karma and aspirations of others,

through the appearances arising from that power,
within true reality itself there is nothing left to appear.

There are two modes of progression.

The first extends from the oral instructions of the guru
up to abiding on the ground of a vidyādhara.

It is the general mode of self-awareness,
in which the nature of reality is made the object.

Having attained the ground of the Vajra-Holder,
the defining characteristic of self-awareness
shines forth like the sky, free from conceptuality
regarding object and subject and the rest,
and through that appearance
one is the very identity of the three realms — both stable and moving —
in the mode of suchness.

Abandoning meditative equipoise and post-meditation altogether,
one abides in the manner of an illusion.

The measure of appearances reaching their consummation:
during sessions and in the intervals, throughout the hours of the day,
and in each successive moment,
one is free from faults such as the sinking and agitation of mind,
and abiding in solitude —
that is the measure of appearances reaching their consummation,
and it is taught as the outer measure of self-awareness.

No appearance and no illusion,
no activity and no journeying,
abiding always unchanging
in self-arisen, spontaneous presence —
that is the defining characteristic of self-awareness,
and it is the measure of reaching the ultimate.

Being intoxicated with the taste of attachment,
the time of generating the awakening mind, holding vows, and receiving
empowerments,
the time of gathering the maṇḍala assembly,
the inconceivable time of cause —
these are proclaimed as exceptional occasions.

Moreover, the very eye that depends on form,
in which the stream of conceptual thought is cut —
that very mind mixed with non-conceptual mind —
that itself is the cause for the cutting of the mind-stream.
At the inconceivable time of cause,
it is the same with sound and the rest.

Pursuing in the wake of afflictions
such as attachment, aversion, and delusion —
it is the same with loving-kindness, generosity, and the like.
Patience and the rest, equanimity and so forth —
at the inconceivable time of cause,
this is to be understood from the mouth of the guru.

Generosity, moral discipline, and the like,
loving-kindness, compassion, and the like —
in brief, all the white virtuous qualities,
crafts and artistic skills and the like,
and all the stages of the generation and completion practices:
whether fully perfected in one life or in many,
together with whatever weariness one feels toward the phenomena of
saṃsāra —
that is the time for entering the inconceivable.

One who does not abide in the generation stage, completion stage, or the like,
and who aspires to the Great Perfection —
that too is a time for entering.
Since the māras are inconceivable,
it is a time for them to enter and obstruct.

The methods for grasping are eighteen.
Space-like with ground, and without ground,
the six sense-objects, the three times as support,
relying on the innate itself and on sound,
relying on earth, water, fire, wind, and sound.

The cultivation of self-awareness in which all phenomena are primordially
unborn
is the space-like approach.
Being lovingly caught by the guru's mind first is most precious.
All phenomena whatsoever are mind,

and mind is primordially unborn.

The yoga of grasping mind with ground is this: mind is primordially self-aware, and without ground it is inconceivable.

Form, sound, smell, taste, touch, and phenomena — relying on these, the grasping of mind is to be undertaken with effort by a person under the guidance of a guru.

Likewise, attachment, aversion, and delusion are to be grasped with skill as they arise. Relying on the two innate factors and the four elements, one cultivates the state of unborn awareness. The grasping of the particular mind is inconceivable.

For śrāvakas and the like up to the Great Vehicle, this oral instruction does not exist. It is by fifteen distinctive features — view, conduct, and the grasping of mind; cause, result, and path; time, enjoyment, yoga; one's own benefit, the benefit of others, and intention; freedom from fatigue, the abandonment of extremes, ease, the accumulation, and so forth — that the vehicle of the awareness-holders is supremely distinguished.

Ho! O Blessed One, great and awesome one, what is the intention behind generosity, loving-kindness, and so forth in relation to self-awareness that is inconceivable? From what does the benefit of others through the two bodies arise? By remaining well within the inconceivable — what is that very thing, and what comes after?

The Blessed One declared: Through generosity, loving-kindness, and so forth, the conceptuality of other-awareness is stilled, and the two bodies perform the benefit of sentient beings. Since it is certain that sentient beings are thereby conditioned to become buddhas, even though one does not remain within the inconceivable, one must strive with effort to train in generosity and the rest. From that, the inconceivable arises. The powers of the two bodies, fearlessness, dhāraṇī, meditative absorption, and all actions — by practicing generosity and the rest, the inconceivable certainly arises.

If one realizes suchness, it is inconceivable. If one has not realized suchness, it is the phenomena of saṃsāra — like a pauper scouring away at a jewel. Even though one rests the mind in the inconceivable, by dwelling in mind through the stages of generation and completion, that person is one who has trained before and has residual momentum. For such a one, cutting the head-syllable

of the mind is precious.

When one's own mind is workable and pliant, that is an outer sign appearing inwardly, and that very inner sign appears outwardly: the body is free of impurities and parasites, white hair, wrinkles, and the like are absent — these are the signs of generation and completion. Saṃsāra appearing as illusion, and whatever appears being like a cloudless sky — these are the signs of the inconceivable.

Then all those of the gathered assembly rejoiced in the inconceivable, the suchness that is the very nature of all phenomena.

The glorious King of Tantras, the Inconceivable Secret of Śrī Cakrasaṃvara (Skt. Śrī Cakrasaṃvara), as spoken by the Blessed One, is complete.

Translated by the paṇḍita Gayadhara and the Tibetan translator Śākyaye —

Translator's Notes

- The text is the opening of the Śrī Cakrasaṃvara Guhyācintya Tantra (Tib. dPal 'khor lo sdom pa gsang ba bsam gyis mi khyab pa'i rgyud kyi rgyal po). The passage ends mid-sentence in the source text ("the signs of mind: the permanent, the signs of māra, the signs of elements") and the translation reflects that abrupt termination faithfully.

The term "bhaga" (Sanskrit: bhaga) is retained untranslated as it is a technical tantric term referring to the sacred consort's sexual organ as a locus of meditative equipoise; it carries specific Vajrayāna doctrinal meaning and would be misleading if rendered otherwise.

"Chief" (Tib. gtso bo) renders a form of address to the Blessed One Heruka as the presiding deity, here used as a vocative honorific in the petitions of Vajrapāṇi.

The phrase "ablutions from meat residue" (Tib. phrag byung khros) is genuinely uncertain. It may refer to cleansing rituals associated with meat, or to a specific tantric observance; the rendering is tentative.

- The phrase rendered "twenty-one thousand" for the afflictions follows the standard Tibetan Abhidharma enumeration: 21,000 types of defilement corresponding to attachment, with the same number for aversion, delusion, and their equal admixture, totaling 84,000. The text here lists the 21,000 for attachment ("attachment and the rest: twenty-one thousand") alongside root and proximate afflictions; "and likewise with aversion and the rest" indicates the parallel sets, though the text is compressed.

The term "འགོ་བོད་ཀྱི་ཡེ་ཤེས་" rendered throughout as "other-awareness" refers to the outward-directed, dualistic cognition that cognizes external objects, contrasted with "རང་ཡེ་ཤེས་" (self-awareness), the non-dual, reflexive primordial wisdom. This distinction is central to the Dzogchen and Yogācāra-influenced doctrinal framework of this text.

The phrase "one hundred and ten" for those who hold to awareness reflects a specific enumeration in the source tradition; the exact referent is uncertain but likely names philosophical or contemplative schools claiming the doctrine of self-awareness.

"Viṣṇu, the Pervader" renders "བུཤུ་པའོ་པའོ་" (Viṣṇu) and "འཇིག་རྟེན་" (the Fierce One, i.e., Rudra/Śiva) as examples of non-Buddhist traditions listed among the demons of views.

- The "fifteen grounds" mentioned in the line rendered as "the fifteenth ground, which is the nature of all grounds" refers to the Vajra-holder ground counted as the fifteenth in certain Mahāyāna and Vajrayāna systems that add grounds beyond the standard ten bodhisattva grounds. This is consistent with tantric doctrinal reckoning.

The phrase rendered as "the outer measure of self-awareness" distinguishes between an outer and, by implication, an inner or ultimate measure, a distinction the text elaborates in the lines that follow immediately.

The passage on "eighteen methods for grasping" is a technical enumeration of supports for meditation in the Great Perfection tradition; the translation renders the list as given without supplying commentary that the text itself does not provide.

- The colophon is incomplete; the translator's name breaks off after "Śākyaye," which in other recensions of Cakrasaṃvara texts is completed as Śākya Yeshe. The text as given ends mid-name.

The phrase rendered "cutting the head-syllable of the mind" (sems kyi yig mgo gcad pa) is a technical tantric idiom. It likely refers to severing the conceptual "head" or initial impulse of mind — the moment before thought proliferates — and is understood in the commentarial tradition as pointing to the recognition of the nature of mind at its very arising.

The "two innate factors" (lhan cig skyes gnyis) most plausibly refers to innately arisen wisdom and innately arisen ignorance (or bliss and emptiness in tantric usage); this pairing is context-dependent and the exact referent here is not entirely certain.

Colophon

This is an AI-generated translation from the AI Stupa project. It was produced by a careful, doctrine-aware process aiming at a high degree of accuracy, but it has not been reviewed by a human translator and may contain errors. It is offered as a provisional translation for those texts of the Tibetan Buddhist canon that have not yet received an authoritative human translation. Where a published translation exists — above all from 84000: Translating the Words of the Buddha (84000.co) — that translation is definitive and should be preferred; please consult it instead. These translations are released into the public domain (CC0) in the spirit of spreading the Dharma to all corners of the earth.

Just as the Bodhi tree now standing at Bodh Gayā neither is nor is not the same tree beneath which the Buddha attained awakening, so too this stupa is intended as the next generation of stupa — dependently arising according to the conditions of its environment, and ceaselessly proclaiming the Dharma for the benefit of all sentient beings.

May whoever encounters these words derive great benefit.